Final Placement

By Ara Watson

MARY: *(To Audience/Dictation)* Last name: James. First name: Jimmy. Age: four years. Date: October ten, 1981. This office was contacted by Dr. Timothy Bowman of the Northside Medical Clinic concerning four-year-old Jimmy James. Dr. Bowman reported that he has treated Jimmy twice in the last six weeks-once for a cut over the eye and once for a broken wrist. The parents attributed both injuries to accidents. On each of the visits, Dr. Bowman noted the child had a number of bruises on his body which the mother explained resulted from Jimmy's-quote-"always falling down"-end quote. On the second of these visits with Jimmy, Dr. Bowman also noted burn marks on the child's buttocks which he believed were caused by a cigarette. He determined at this point to contact this office and request an investigation of the situation by the Department.

INTRODUCTION

Placements in foster care have dramatically increased over the past 10 years. Today over 500,000 children in the U.S. currently reside in some form of foster care. What leads to such drastic measures by social service workers? Simply put, many of these children have suffered some form of serious abuse or neglect—removal of these children from their homes is a protective measure. The situation is stressful for all involved . . . parents, children and the social workers who attempt to intervene in the best interest of the child. Stress often leads to parental violence directed toward the social workers themselves. In fact, Seventy (70) percent of front-line caseworkers have been victims of violence or received threats of violence. In protecting children from domestic violence, the very people who intervene become targets themselves.

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MARY: What are-? *(A moment's hesitation.)* Hello. You . . . you startled me.

LUELLEN: There wasn't no one at the front desk.

MARY: Oh? Well, she. . . she must have stepped away a minute.

LUELLEN: I heard your voice, so I followed it, but I didn't want to disturb you. Boy, sure is quiet up here.

MARY: Yes. Yes, I guess it is.

LUELLEN: Where is everybody anyway? Looks like you're the only one in the whole place.

MARY: *(quickly lying)* No. Everybody's here. They're all . . . just busy. . . keeping their heads down. But. . . they're all here. I like your hair like that.

LUELLEN: Needs cuttin'.

MARY: No, I like it longer. Makes you look . . .It's nice. *(Slight pause.)* How is . . . Are you all right?

LUELLEN: I walked all the way here.

MARY: From your house?

LUELLEN: Must be ten miles, I bet. Don't you think it's about that? 'Bout ten miles?

MARY: Well . . . It's certainly longer than I'd care to walk, anyway. Especially today. Did you. . . come just co see me or . . . ? *(Luellen nods but avoids looking at Mary.)* Well, I'm glad to see you, Luellen, but, you know, it might have been better if you'd called me first . . . to make sure I was in, that I didn't have a client with me . . . *(Luellen still doesn't look at her.)* You lucked out, I guess.

MARY: *(To Audience/Dictation)* The worker has visited twice weekly with Jimmy since his removal from the James home and his subsequent placement in foster care on October 19. Mr. and Ms. James have remained in group therapy, and it is that group leader's judgment that both, but especially Ms. James, have made substantial progress. As a result, the court has ordered that supervised trial visits between Jimmy and his natural parents begin immediately with the goal of eventual reintegration of the James family.

MARY: Luellen, you walked a very long way on a very hot day to see me . . . Luellen? . . . *(Luellen looks at her quickly and then away.)* I would like to know why - what I can do to help you - but you are going to have to tell me. *(No response.)* Will you? *(No*

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response.) Well. I'm sorry, I wish I had more time, but I do have this appointment, so, if you'll let me get my things together, I'll take you . . .

LUELLEN: *(quickly and with a new energy)* No, but, see, see, I got this real good idea. It's real good, too. See, I'm fixin' to move out on Ol' Ray. He just don't know it yet, but I am. I'm goin' to get me a place to live and I'm goin' to get me a job maybe with the phone company maybe. My girlfriend works for the phone company. Or a waitress. I could do that.

MARY: Jobs are a little hard to find these days, but. . . but that sounds. . . I think you'd enjoy working . . .

LUELLEN: *(big smile)* I think I would, too; and my girlfriend lives in a duplex and her neighbors is goin' to move maybe and I could move in there if they did. It's got a fenced-in backyard and a big side yard and I wouldn't even let Ol' Ray even come visit only if he got over doin' them things.

MARY: *(realizing)* Wait a minute

LUELLEN: *(going on)* I know he don't mean to. He just loses his temper sometimes is all, but he's gettin' a whole lot better 'bout it since we went to that group. I sure to 'preciate you makin' us go to them meetin's. See, we had a lot of pressure on us and we was probably just takin' it out on . . .

MARY: Luellen. Wait a minute here.

LUELLEN: No, no. I still wouldn't let him' come and stay. Not no matter how much he yelled at me or how much 'he begged me, he couldn't. A daddy don't need to be with his son like a mama does. *(Slightly choked, but going on.)* A mama needs to be with her child. You know that, don't you? I know you do and I'm goin' to get a place for me and Jimmy to live and you can . . .

MARY: You know that's . . .

LUELLEN: *(going on)* And you could come visit Jimmy ever'day. You could take him out in your car and you could buy him a Coke and ask him questions. . . I'd share him with you. We could share him. *(She looks pleadingly at Mary. Pause.)*

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MARY: Luellen, please don't do this to yourself.

LUELLEN: I ain't

MARY: You're hurting yourself with this. You're building up a fantasy that

LUELLEN: It ain't a fantasy. I thought it all out.

MARY: Thinking it out doesn't mean it can happen that way.

LUELLEN: *(a protest)* Yes!

MARY: No. I'm sorry.

LUELLEN: *(looks at her a moment quietly)* You ain't sorry.

MARY: Yes, I am. I'm sorry for how you feel right now. I know how very

LUELLEN: You know what? You know what it's like to have your kid stole by the Welfare? To sit in a room and remember that your little boy ain't bein' quiet 'cause he's sleepin' or into somethin', but that he's bein' quiet 'cause he ain't even there no more. And you don't know where he is or when he's comin' back? You don't know.

MARY: No. I guess. . . no one can. . . really. . . but you have to. . .

LUELLEN: *(watching her coldly)* What? I have to what? Forget about him? You ain't got no kids, do you?

MARY: No.

LUELLEN: No. You want one?

MARY: Someday. . .

LUELLEN: Like my Jimmy? *(Mary doesn't answer this.)* I know you like him a whole lot. You like him better than the other ones? He your favorite? You know what Ol' Ray told me once after you'd come out to visit? He said, "You better watch out, Lu girl. That woman wants your baby for herself and she's a' gonna get him, too." That's what he said, but I didn't believe him. Sometimes, though, that Ray knows what he's talkin' 'bout. You got him?

MARY: What?

LUELLEN: You got him at your house, ain't you?

MARY: No. That's

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LUELLEN: You don't want me to know where you live 'cause

MARY: This is a state agency. There are rules here, Luellen. Even if I wanted to do something like-

LUELLEN: Oh, you want to. You want to and you did. *(The two look at each other a long moment.)*

MARY: *(reasonably)* No matter how much I care about Jimmy -- and I do, I care about him -- that simply isn't the reason he was taken out of your home. You know that. I did not "steal" him. He is not at my house. O.K.? Now. I want you to tell me precisely what it is you think I can do, so I can answer you in as clear a way as possible. . . so we understand each other.

LUELLEN: *(trying to be "reasonable" in turn)* I want to see Jimmy.

MARY: I understand that, but what do you want me to do?

LUELLEN: I want you to go get him.

MARY: I can't do that. I don't have that authority. It's out of my hands.

LUELLEN: You go get him and bring him here.

MARY: I can't

LUELLEN: Go get him.

MARY: You were in the courtroom. You heard what the judge said.

LUELLEN: Then call him.

MARY: Who?

LUELLEN: Call that judge. Right now. Tell him I can have my baby back.

MARY: I'm not going to argue with you

LUELLEN: Call him.

MARY: This interview is ended.

LUELLEN: Call him. *(She moves in on Mary.)*

MARY: I can't call the judge!

LUELLEN: Yes, you can! *(Continuing to move in on Mary -- cold and menacing.)* And you better.

MARY: *(backing away, fear showing)* Luellen.

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LUELLEN: You better do it. *(She is almost in Mary's face.)*

MARY: Get out of my face.

LUELLEN: *(fists clenched)* I mean it!

MARY: Now . . . stop this!

LUELLEN: If you don't, I'll do something. I'll hurt you. I can. I ain't kiddin' either.

MARY: God-damn-it! God-damn-it! *(Turns on Luellen who steps back)* Just who the hell do you think you are? What do you think you're doing here? You can't ever-not ever in this life-see that child again. Not ever.

LUELLEN: *(more of a cry)* Yes, I can. .

MARY: Do you think the state or the judge would put that little boy back after what you did?

LUELLEN: I didn't. . . I never done -- Ray. Ray done it.

MARY: You! You! Face that reality at least. You. You admitted it to me, to the judge

LUELLEN: *(shaking her head)* Ray.

MARY: Ray may have done a lot of it, but not that last, Luellen.

LUELLEN: *(childlike)* Well . . . he made me.

MARY: He made you hold that child's hands on a hot stove till he had first- and second-degree burns? I'll tell you one thing, Ray couldn't have made me do that!

LUELLEN: *(meekly)* We was just teaching him

MARY: *(going on)* And, then, you ran off and left him, just left him -- and in all the months we've had him in foster care, you haven't contacted me once, not one time, to find out how he was doing. So why today? Why do you people suddenly turn up out of the blue and think -- Christ. *(Takes a breath to calm herself)* We explained everything to you six months ago. *(Brief pause.)* You could hold a gun to my head or a knife to my throat and it still wouldn't get him back for you. *(Pause.)*

MARY: *(To Audience/Dictation)* *Jimmy was taken to the State Office for final adoptive placement with his new family on September 3, 1982.*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

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